Davis and Aptheker were inspired to open *If They Come in the Morning* with an excerpt from Baldwin's letter as they frame the repressive thrust of American history and its direct ties to the conditions of prisons. *If They Come in the Morning* was envisioned as an educational and fundraising tool for her case and a publication that valued intellectual creativity as a means for gaining her and others' freedom. Davis and Aptheker attempt to contextualize prison within histories of enslavement, imperialism, and the law-and-order politics of the 1960s and 1970s. They reference global coalitions to free Angela, and the potential of a "united front" in which individual cases are leveraged to make a larger point about structures of injustice—in other words, to transform the system through a "thematic unity of resistance" that recognizes the ways in which "repression cuts across ideological boundaries."[50] Walls are referred to over twenty times in the volume, including eight references by Davis and instances mentioned by others including Fleeta Drumgo, John Clutchette, Ericka Huggins, and Huey Newton. (Other allusions to barriers and other analogous symbols occur throughout the text.)

One of the book's contributors, Huggins, an incarcerated member of the Black Panthers who would later be acquitted of criminal charges, offered a poem that critically treats and then transforms the symbol of walls. In her chapter "Poems from Prison," which she penned while incarcerated, Huggins writes of the "noises / sounds / unspoken words" that were "repressed" by prison walls. She closes with a vision that prisons are "soul walls / barriers / if only all barriers could be removed."[51] Huggins exemplifies an emerging sentiment found within this collection. The spatial imagination of this poem highlights prisoners' expressive and critical thoughts in a way to call to abolish and transform prison walls into spaces of necessary connection.

In a group of collected writings, Davis's own prose in *If They Come in the Morning* structures portions of the book in which walls are rendered through philosophical and symbolic terms. Across the text, Davis is credited with ten essays or letters out of the twenty-nine featured in the book, and at least an additional eight are addressed directly to her or engage specifics of her case. The section of the book titled "Angela Y. Davis" also features the *Political Biography* credited to her defense committee and a series of transcripts from interviews between Davis and counsel Margaret Burnham in